

THEFAB COOKBOOK - VOLUME I

Homemade Bolognaise

A slow red sauce with fresh tomatoes, canned peeled tomatoes, sage, chicken broth and very good pepper. It is rustic, generous and designed to perfume the whole kitchen while the machines are warming up.

Serves 6	Prep 25 min	Cook 2.5-3 h	Style Slow sauce / family table
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TheFAB studio note

Sage and chicken broth make this sauce warmer and more personal than a strict ragu. It should be thick, glossy and deep, not watery.

Ingredients

- 700 g minced beef, or 500 g beef + 200 g pork
- 2 onions, finely chopped
- 2 carrots, finely diced
- 2 celery sticks, finely diced
- 3 garlic cloves, chopped
- 4 fresh ripe tomatoes, diced
- 1 large can peeled skinless tomatoes, crushed by hand
- 2 tbsp tomato paste
- 200 ml dry red wine
- 300-400 ml chicken broth
- 8-10 fresh sage leaves, finely chopped
- 1 bay leaf
- Olive oil and a knob of butter
- Sea salt and plenty of freshly ground black pepper
- Optional: 100 ml whole milk near the end for a softer sauce

Method

- 1 Warm olive oil and butter in a heavy pot. Sweat the onions, carrots and celery slowly until sweet and translucent, about 12 minutes.
- 2 Add the garlic and sage for 1 minute, then raise the heat and brown the meat very well. Do not rush this step; the taste starts here.
- 3 Stir in the tomato paste and cook for 2 minutes. Pour in the wine and reduce until the alcohol has cooked off.
- 4 Add the fresh tomatoes, canned peeled tomatoes, bay leaf and enough chicken broth to loosen the sauce.
- 5 Simmer very gently, uncovered or half-covered, for 2.5 to 3 hours. Add broth when needed and stir from time to time.
- 6 Finish with a lot of good black pepper. Add milk for the final 15 minutes if you want a rounder, softer finish. Serve with tagliatelle or rigatoni.



Proposed wine pairing

A pairing designed to support the main character of the dish rather than overpower it.

Best match	Chianti Classico or another Sangiovese-based Tuscan red.
Also works	Barbera d'Alba, Montepulciano d'Abruzzo, or a medium-bodied Tuscan red from Maremma.
Why it works	Bright acidity cuts through the tomato and meat, while moderate tannins support the slow-cooked depth without dominating the sauce.
Serving note	Choose freshness over power. A very oaky or very alcoholic red can flatten the tomato and sage.

Personal adjustment: choose a bottle you would happily drink even without the dish. Pairing should amplify pleasure, not become an exam.